Translator brief: the city laments (the Lament for Ur, the Curse of Agade), 2026-10-19

A common brief for the sequential translators of `1-הקינה-על-אור/` (ETCSL 2.2.2) and `2-קללת-אכד/` (ETCSL 2.1.5). Reusable for any later Sumerian lament. Adapted from `../סיפורי-הבריאה-המסופוטמיים/translator-brief--sumerian.md`. The coordinator's per-run prompt says which lines are yours.

0. Read first (binding, in this order)

1. `../translation-guidelines.md` — whole. Especially §1 (**two purposes**: the Bible comparison *and* "the soul of the ancients"), §5 (workflow and the lessons), §6 (principles; echo control §6.4; false friends §6.7), §6.8 (brackets), §7.2 (the annotated format).
2. `corpus.md`, then `renderings.md` (**all of it is binding**; §3 fixes the refrains, §5 the reserved strings).
3. The creation corpus's Sumerian renderings (`../סיפורי-הבריאה-המסופוטמיים/renderings.md` §5–§8) – they are the default for every word not in our file; and skim `../סיפורי-הבריאה-המסופוטמיים/4-אנקי-וסדר-העולם/annotated-1.rtl.md` (a model for the format and the depth of the apparatus).
4. Your project's `project.md` and `renderings.md`, and **the Hebrew of every earlier run** (`python3 -I lament_tools.py grep all '<regex>'`). Read the previous files of your own project in full before you start.

1. Rules learned the hard way (put them first)

- **Draft unvocalized, in plene spelling (כתיב מלא), from the very first line.** Vocalize only names at their first occurrence, ambiguous words, and the names that are always vocalized (★ in renderings §1: Urim אוּר, Sumer שׁוּמֶר, An אַן, Inana אִינַנָּה, Utu אוּתוּ, Umma אוּמָּה, Bau בָּאוּ, Keš כֶּשׁ, Šara שָׁרָא, Ezina דָּגָן, *me* הַ֫מָּה). Never strip niqqud with a naive regex (it deletes the maqaf): keep [illegible]. Three earlier translators drafted vocalized and had to rewrite everything.
- **Translate the Sumerian, not ETCSL's English.** Form your reading from the transliteration, ETCSL's TEI lemmas, the ORACC lemma + morph (`../sources/ORACC/epsd2-literary--Q000379--Lament-for-Ur/Q000379--lemmatised-morph.md`, `...--Q000375--Curse-of-Agade/Q000375--lemmatised-morph.md`; same line labels; the Agade Ur III segments as "Ver.2, Seg.X, N") and ePSD2; read ETCSL's translation (rank 3) only afterwards and record every disagreement. ETCSL's English has repeatedly imported biblical language in this programme ("not yet", "cursed", "created", "firmament"); here watch for "righteous" (*zid*), "exile", "glory", "abandon", "daughter", "lament" – check each against the Sumerian.

- **The verbal chain.** In the **פירוק** bullet parse every finite verb: prefix chain (modal *ḫe₂-* / *ḫa-* / *ḫu-*, *ga-*, *u₃-*, *nu-*, *na-*, *ba-ra-* "not"; conjugation prefix *mu-*, *i₃-*, *ba-*, *bi₂-*, *im-ma-*, *am₃-*; dimensional infixes *-na-*, *-da-*, *-ta-*, *-ši-*, *-ni-*; agent *-n-*/*-b-*), the base (ḫamṭu or marû, reduplication) and suffixes (*-e*, *-eš*, *-ene*, nominaliser *-a*, *-am₃*). Say where the morph comes from (ORACC, or `../tools/sumerian_workbench.py morph`, or **"ניתוח שלנו"**). **Name every Emesal form and its main-dialect equivalent** (renderings §2).
- **Sumerian → Hebrew grammar** (creation corpus): narrative marû = participle; ḫamṭu = past; *ḫe₂-* = jussive/wish – **but in the Lament for Ur *ḫe₂-* with ḫamṭu in a narrative is often affirmative ("indeed ...")**: decide by context and say so; *ga-* = cohortative; *u₃-* = "after/when"; non-finite *-a* = relative clause or infinitive; *nu-* = `לֹא` (never `טֶרֶם`); *ba-ra-* = emphatic negation `לֹא` (`לֹא ... כְּלָל` only if needed); copula *-am₃* = nominal sentence.
- **One line = one Hebrew line**, with ETCSL's label. The *kirugu* and *ĝišgiĝal* rubric lines are lines: translate them (`קִירוּגוּ רִאשׁוֹן.` , `הַגִּישְׁגִּיגַל שָׁלוֹ.` – renderings §4). Keep the break, the order of images, the parallelism and **every repetition: identical Sumerian → identical Hebrew** (the refrains are fixed in renderings §3 and checked by script; `verify` lists the rest).
- **Brackets**: a word whose root is broken in the composite is in `[]`; `[...]` for a lost stretch; `...` for a word ETCSL leaves untranslated or an `X`; `()` added for sense; `?` uncertain reading; `נטוי` uncertain translation; `‹›` scribal omission. ETCSL manuscript variants ("1 ms. has instead/adds") go in the apparatus, with their Hebrew when they change the sense. The pluses of some manuscripts (18A, 100A, 209A, 432A, 87A, 87B, 93A, 11A) are entries of their own.
- **Reserved and gated strings** (renderings §5) are checked by script; the run fails if one slips in. Before you choose a word that the Bible comparison needs (`נטש` , `עזב` , `ארר` , `קלל` , `שוב` , `תל` , `נכרי` , `אויב` , `מר` , `אנחה` , `עד מתי` , `אוי` , `הוי` , `דמעה`), check that the Sumerian word is the one the renderings assign to it. **Tag every such word in the apparatus.**
- **Bible quotations** in the apparatus: vocalized, in backticks, followed by the reference in the repository's format (`(איכה א:א)`), copied from `../../../תנך-מנוקד/` (`python3 -I ../tools/check_bible_quotes.py --show "איכה א"` prints a verse) and verified with `python3 -I ../tools/check_bible_quotes.py <file>`. The Hebrew Bible's chapter and verse numbering (e.g. Jer 31:14, not 31:15). Fix every mismatch. Keep the `-` of Psalms and Proverbs.

2. The annotated file (guidelines §7.2)

Header (Hebrew): title `# ... – תרגום מוער (חלק N: שורות X–Y)`; then paragraphs **נוסח הבסיס**, **פירוק** (where the lemmas and morph come from), **אמסל** (what Emesal is, how this file treats it: renderings §2), **תגי הקבלה**, **תרגומים להשוואה**, **סימנים**, **מספור**, a paragraph that explains the text on its own terms (first file of each project: what a city lament is and how it was used; the *kirugu* / *ĝišgiĝal* form; the fall of Ur III / Akkad and the Gutians; later files: the part of the story you

translate), **מלים שמורות**, **שמות**. Then `---`, then sections `## <from>–<to>: <Hebrew heading>` (the clean translation takes its headings from these; one section per *kirugu* + its *ĝišgiĝal* in the Lament for Ur, by content in Agade), then one entry per ETCSL line:

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### 81
`e-ne-ra nam uru₂-na mu-na-te er₂ gig i₃-še₈-še₈`
> דמעות מרות היא בוכה — עִירוֹ נִיגְשָׁה אֵלָיו לְמַעַן.
- **פירוק:** … (every word; the verbal chain; Emesal forms; the source of the mo
- **תרגומים:** ETCSL: "…" — agreement / disagreement and why. (Kramer 1940, if y
- **הקבלה:** [equivalent] `(איכה א:ב) בָּכוֹ תִבְכֶּה בַּלָּיְלָה וְדִמְעָתָהּ עַל לֶחֱיָהּ` — … (only r
- **הערות:** the line on its own terms: the image, the realia, the ritual, the t
- **הערת שוליים:** (optional) one sentence that the clean translation should car
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- The transliteration line is copied **exactly** from ETCSL's `transliteration.md` (the text after the label, including ETCSL's `...` catalogue notes and variant parentheses, or without them – the script ignores both, but nothing else may differ). `python3 -I lament_tools.py lines KEY FROM-TO` prints your lines.
- For the Agade Ur III segments use the labels `A1` … `F7` and one section per segment (`## קטע A (נוסח אור השלישית)`).
- **`הערות` matters as much as `הקבלה`** (guidelines §1): a city and its god; the goddess's plea; the gods' assembly; the irrevocable word; the storm as Enlil's decision; Emesal and the *gala*; how the laments were performed; the herds and the dairy, the canals, the festivals and dances, the granaries, the debt-prison, the nursemaids; the Elamites, Šimaški and the Gutians; Agade's trade with Meluḫḫa and Dilmun; omens, dreams and extispicy; temple building and why it needs the god's consent; what made a king's act sacrilege. Not every line needs a note; the ones that open the ancient mind do.
- Not every line has a parallel; never force one. **[absent]** and **[divergence]** are findings too (e.g. no sin of the city in the Lament for Ur; no human guilt at all until 1 ms. of the last prayer; in Lamentations the city's sin is the cause).

3. Tools

- `python3 -I ../tools/sumerian_workbench.py lemmas <c.xml> FROM-TO` — ETCSL's TEI lemmas per word; `line <c.xml> FROM-TO` adds ORACC morph for each verb where the same form is parsed elsewhere; `morph '<form>'`; `conc '<regex>' [--lemma]` (ETCSL-wide concordance: formulas recur, e.g. in the other city laments 2.2.3–2.2.6 – look them up before fixing a line); `gloss '<regex>'` (ePSD2 glossary). The XML: `../sources/ETCSL/2.2.2--Lament-for-Ur/c.2.2.2.xml`, `../sources/ETCSL/2.1.5--Curse-of-Agade/c.2.1.5.xml`.
- `python3 -I lament_tools.py verify LU|CA` (coverage, transliteration = ETCSL, one `>` per entry, reserved strings, name traps, refrains, identical lines); `grep all '<regex>'`; `lines`.

- The clean translation is **generated**: the coordinator writes `translation--intro.rtl.md` and runs `lament_tools.py build`. Never write `translation.rtl.md` by hand.

4. Before you finish (each run)

1. Three review passes over your lines (guidelines §5.6: fidelity; consistency with `renderings.md` and the earlier Hebrew; Hebrew read aloud), each a separate read-through; record them in `project.md` ("Progress").
2. `python3 -I lament_tools.py verify <KEY>` clean for your lines (notes about not-yet-drafted files are fine); `python3 -I ../tools/check_bible_quotes.py <your annotated file>` clean.
3. In `project.md`, under your run's heading: the **parallels index** `### Parallels index (<KEY>)` (KEY = LU1, LU2, LU3, CA1, CA2) as a table with exactly the columns `| Line | Sumerian | Hebrew rendering | Bible | Tag | Comment |` (the header row starts with `| Line`; Line = the ETCSL label; Bible = the vocalized verse(s) in backticks followed by the reference); your **key findings** (Bible; and the ancient mind) in a few sentences; your **open decisions** (numbered); and **Proposals for the corpus renderings** (new terms a later run will need, with the Hebrew strings exactly as you used them).
4. Add your text-specific terms to the project's `renderings.md` (table: Sumerian | Hebrew | Tag | Notes | Lines).
5. Do **not** edit the corpus files (`corpus.md`, `renderings.md`, `parallels-index.md`, the tools), the guidelines, or any other project: the coordinator merges. Do not commit.
6. Final message to the coordinator (short): lines done, verify / quote-check status, the strongest findings (Bible, and the ancient mind), open decisions, and any deviation from the corpus renderings (with the reason).